

Bought

tal popularity skyrocket. For the present election season, Bhatia says several politicians have reached out to him offering him millions of rupees for coverage.

In an interview to the BBC last month, he said, "But they wanted me to share questions in advance or get the video approved before it's published." He declined the offers in order to maintain editorial control of his content. Instead, the past month has seen him push out informal, off-the-cuff interviews with Omar Abdullah, K.T. Rama Rao, Rajeev Shukla, Sitaram Yechury, Prashant Kishor, Tej Pratap Yadav and Saurabh Bhardwaj. His content ranges from serious issues of economy and democracy to light-hearted conversation about Omar Abdullah's diet coke addiction or K.T. Rama Rao's shoe size.

-Sonali Acharjee

AFTER A YEAR OF COURTING THEM, RAHUL GANDHI'S CLOSE AIDES SAY THE IDEA OF ENGAGING WITH INFLUENCERS HAS LOST NOVELTY

we believe Rahul's account is suppressed and has even higher potential, he doesn't need amplification through other sources."

The BJP's quest to dominate the digital space this election season, on the other hand, has seen a few changes. Even as WhatsApp continues to be the mainstay to disseminate poll-related messaging (the party is said to be maintaining a stack of five million groups), party insiders say there are about 216 million people below 30, or 22.3 per cent of the electorate, who consume news and entertainment on smaller screens. Till the 2019 election, Facebook (now Meta) would corner the biggest pie of the ad budget; come 2024, it's crisply-edited visual content—Insta reels and YouTube shorts—where the money goes. The aim, leaders involved in the process say, is to drive engagement. The party has adopted a three-pronged strategy: engage first with the influencers with a wide subscriber base on the national level, then converse with local influencers in the vernacular languages at the state level and, finally, micro-detail the audience in the constituency at the candidate level. "The electorate wants to understand the personality of their leaders, not just their political views," says a top BJP leader, though he feels that social media doesn't change people's opinion quickly, only reaffirms their existing beliefs.

ROCKY ROAD AHEAD

It's not easy being an influencer weighing in on political and social issues. The free rein they have had being their own bosses could be coming to an end. The Broadcasting Services Regulation Bill, 2023, which seeks to replace the existing Cable Television Networks Regulation Act of 1995, intends to bring over-the-top (OTT) and digital news platforms under its ambit. Digital content creators have already begun getting targeted. In 2022, Poulami Nag, who runs the Bengali channel Hothat Jodi Uthlo Kotha (Bringing up a discussion), had to secure bail from the Calcutta High Court over her video about government hospital beds being sold out.

The Ranting Gola, a 23-year-old who seeks to combat "fascism ke jokers with comedy", has had her Insta account shut down for her no-holds-barred takes packaged in short clips. She remains unfazed, saying, "You can take away my account, but not my courage!! In democracy, you are entitled to ask questions, you are entitled to laugh at their mistakes..." Rathee, too, does the same; only he packages the work of journalists with his engaging commentary to alert his subscribers. There's support from his family back in India but also concern. Rathee wouldn't have it any other way. "I have taken a stand," he says, "and I am proud of what I have done these elections regardless of what happens later." It's a credo his cohort of internet warriors echo readily. ■

with Kaushik Deka, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Debjani Saha